"The government is making efforts to improve marketing and remuneration for organic farmers"

Taking forward Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision for cleaner agriculture, Union agriculture minister **NARENDRA TOMAR** *outlines the plans to push natural and organic farming in a conversation with* **ANILESH S. MAHAJAN**

Q. PM Modi and your ministry are pushing hard to unleash the potential of natural and organic farming. What all have you done so far?

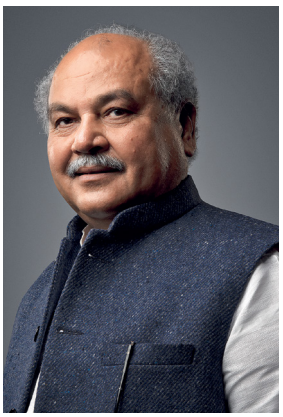
A. PM Modi has strongly batted for natural farming. This has raised awareness for this form of agriculture in the country. Last year in December, at Gujarat's Anand, the state's governor, Acharya Devvrat, made a strong presentation in front of thousands of farmers. Natural farming, under the ministry's Paramparagat Krishi Vikas Yojana (PKVY), is now done in farms spread over 5 lakh hectares. States like Himachal Pradesh, Gujarat and Andhra Pradesh alone have 3 lakh hectares of these farms, followed closely by Madhya Pradesh. The satisfaction is that the awareness about natural farming is increasing. Consumers, too, are getting more health-conscious; that is increasing the demand for natural and organic food products. The segment is also attracting young entrepreneurs.

Q. Where do you see the country's organic production going in the next five years? In which areas is your ministry working to realise the potential of organic farming?

A. India has made strong and unprecedented progress in organic farming. The country stands fourth in the world today in terms of area under organic farming and tops the list in terms of organic products. The area under organic farming was 11.8 lakh hectare in 2013-14 and has crossed 38 lakh hectare now [under PKVY, Namami Gange, National Program for Organic Production and Bharatiya Prakritik Krishi Paddhati]. It has already benefitted 15 lakh farmers practising farming on 12 lakh hectares. The initial focus is on the 5 km corridor along the Ganga. States too have been incentivised to support organic and natural farming. To achieve this, we have formed a high-level committee of scientists and experts, and work is in progress.

Q. What are you doing to build the market infrastructure for the same?

A. The government is making efforts to improve the market access for organic and natural farmers and get good remuneration for produce. For certification of the produce, organic groups have to be linked with Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs) which can ensure them post-harvest facilities. For the Northeast alone, 170 FPOs have been formed so far. These FPOs are helping farmers market their produce directly. Other than this, 130 FPOs have been floated under PKVY. In the future, too, the plan is to link all organic and natural farmers with markets through these FPOs.



"THE DEMAND FOR ORGANIC FOOD IS RISING AS PEOPLE TURN MORE HEALTH-CONSCIOUS. YOUNG ENTREPRENEURS ARE GETTING ATTRACTED TO THE SEGMENT"

Q. PM Modi is a strong votary of crop diversification. The push for organic and natural farming and minimum support price (MSP) for oilseeds and pulses were seen as steps in that direction. What has been our success so far?

A. The government regularly fixes the MSP for 22 crops and the FRP (fair & remunerative price) for sugarcane. Under the National Food Security Mission, states are assisted to buy pulses, millets, oilseeds, cotton etc.; the Centre and states are buying 25 per cent of oilseeds and pulses from the farmers. Any proposal from the states to make further purchases is cleared quickly. This is already reflecting in pulse production numbers. Pulse production rose to 27 million tonnes in 2021-22 from 16.3 MT in 2015-16, a massive 65 per cent jump. This has also helped us bring down imports to 2.32 MT in 2020-21 from 6.36 MT in 2016-17. PM Modi has also committed to forming a committee to ensure transparency and smooth implementation of MSP. Crop diversification and promotion of organic and natural farming will be a critical component in it.